Wednesday, November 4, 2026

Hey folks, I just got done grading the Reattempts, and I'm proud of so much of what I'm seeing in this class.

I'm maybe most proud of the students who've come to my office, told me that they were having difficulty with some concept we've covered, asked me about what was confusing them, had a conversation about it, went home to put in the work, and Passed on their second or third Attempt. That is excellence.

On Monday I had a student come in to tell me she was struggling. She hadn't yet Passed many of the skills in Part B and wasn't sure what to do. We had a little conversation about the material and made a plan to put in the work. Last week I had many students drop in for a check-in after doing some make-up practice. When I asked how it went, what I heard over and over was so inspiring to me, something like, "I didn't fully get it at first and I didn't pass the skill on the Checkpoint, but going back through, it makes way more sense this time." And it shows on the Reattempts. So many students in the class, and I mean hundreds, have leveled up through practice before trying again. That is excellence.

Excellence is not necessarily mastering the material on the first go. It's great if you do. But there will be times when that doesn't happen. And that's more than ok. What matters is what you do next.

> *Excellence is the process of putting in the work to go from not understanding to understanding.*

Excellence is coming to class, taking the notes you need, doing the practice along the way, asking questions about what you don't understand in the practice, and going back to what you have not yet mastered.

I also noticed many students didn't come back to Reattempt skills they hadn't passed yet. Remember the lesson here. A Not Yet only means something if you try again. A Not Yet you never come back to is just a No.

In this class, as in the rest of your life, a skill you pass on your third attempt counts the same as one you pass on your first. No one is an expert when they start out. So

make up the practice, unlock the skill, and come sit the Reattempt for any skill from Parts A, B, and C. The next chance is this Thursday or Friday in your recitation.

This is what we do in the academy when we're at our best. At the bleeding edge of science, research is this process, how we learn something no one else knows and no one exists to teach us. It's how we organize the preliminary exams in our PhD program, where you get to show what you've mastered right after the first-year coursework and then try again later in the summer after studying what you missed. And it's the foundation of every part of the learning process at all levels, including an introductory class like this.

For most people, Microeconomics takes work. Generations of thinkers have shaped this banquet of big ideas in front of you. Your job is to engage in the process of excellence, of putting in the work to understand them.

I'm more than doubling my office hours this week: 2:30 PM to 4:45 PM on Wednesday (today) and Thursday (tomorrow). Drop in for a little conversation. Office hours have been busy lately, so if it is, stick around and we'll find time.

Lastly, I've been thinking about how to recognize the excellence I'm seeing from you and your classmates. To cover the skills that still don't stick for you after reattempting, I've decided to drop one skill for every Part we get through this semester. We've assessed Parts A, B, and C, with D being graded. By the end of the semester you'll have six skills automatically dropped if you don't pass them. They're there as a safety net, not a reason to skip a Reattempt. Your final grade will be the percentage of the remaining skills you pass.

With love,

Taylor